

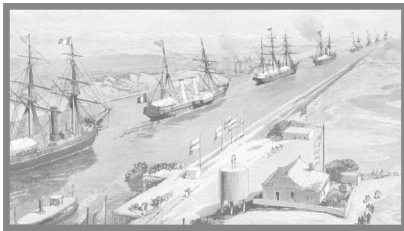
and Hong Kong by 26 percent. The impact on trade was plain to see. However, reduced sailing times also greatly simplified the defense of India and its crucial markets, Britain's key imperial goal. By the end of the 19th century, trade in the Indian Ocean, protected by no fewer than 21 Royal Navy bases, had become almost a British monopoly, a point further underlined when Britain gained control of the Suez Canal in 1888 after having invaded and occupied Egypt six years earlier. This "gunboat diplomacy" proved a remarkably effective means of protecting British interests.

The Panama Canal

The Suez Canal was just one of a number of similar massive engineering undertakings in the interest of imperial trade. An even more challenging project was the construction, begun in 1881, of the Panama Canal in Central America, linking the Atlantic and Pacific oceans. It, too, was a French initiative, but one dogged by controversy and a consistently hostile climate that cost the lives of 22,000 laborers. The United States eventually completed the Panama Canal in August 1914, stepping in when the French finally admitted defeat. It was the largest and most expensive engineering project in the world. It, too, dramatically reduced sailing times, shortening the Liverpool to San Francisco route by 42 percent, and the New York to San Francisco route by 60 percent.

US involvement

The fact that the United States took over the construction of the Panama Canal



The Suez Canal opened in 1869 and dramatically cut sailing times between Europe and Asia. This provided a massive boost for trade, which, in turn, spurred technological advances.

underlines a crucial shift in US attitudes: they were committing not just to expanding trade but also to advancing US overseas interests. This had begun in 1898, when the US itself became a colonial power, taking over the Philippines from Spain.

The process began to accelerate under the presidency of Theodore Roosevelt (1901–1909). He actively advocated US military involvement, above all, in Latin America, to ensure stability as a means of advancing American interests. One consequence of this was his strengthening of the US Navy, the Great White Fleet.

Roosevelt's successor, William Taft, pursued a more legalistic variant of the policy—Dollar Diplomacy—by which American commercial interests, chiefly in Latin America and East Asia, were to be secured by the full backing of the US government, and huge overseas investments encouraged.

Trains and telegraphs

At the same time, major new railroads were constructed in both the US and Europe. The east and west coasts of the US were first linked by rail in 1869, with the opening of the 1,907-mile (3,070-km) Central Pacific Railroad. By 1905, there were eight more transcontinental rail lines across the United States and one in Canada.

The building of the Trans-Siberian Railroad in Russia, between 1891 and 1905, was undertaken in the same spirit. A remarkable 4,600 miles (7,400 km) long and spanning seven time zones, it remains the longest continuous railroad in the world. It played a key role not just in the settlement of Russia's vast Siberian territories, but in Russia's encroachment on parts of northern China, too.

The impact of the telegraph was just as significant, allowing messages to be communicated along electrical lines. Samuel Morse devised the system in the United States in the 1830s, and the first telegraph line was inaugurated in May 1844. Within a decade, there were 20,000 miles (32,200 km) of telegraph cable in the US.

The first telegraph cable across the Atlantic, laid in 1858, worked for only two »